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If the U.S. is to realize the transformative possibilities of AI while also mitigating its risks, it will require a mobilization of all of our intellectual resources. We urge an expansive strategy that complements commercial competitiveness with greater involvement of humanities researchers to ensure both strategic and judicious development. This path requires significant investment in research alongside collaboration with other nations where these technologies are being developed. To balance the speed of innovation, we advocate for transparency and access for academic researchers to independently assess potential use cases and associated harms. There is no reason to place blind trust in these systems when it comes to our security, values, or welfare. Ongoing discussion, testing, and oversight are essential for technologies that have such powerful societal effects. Given the profound societal, economic, and security implications of AI, we must not underestimate the power of these systems. This situation goes beyond the usual debates about innovation versus regulation. While privately held companies are incentivized to prioritize performance and competitiveness, academic research and government oversight can complement these efforts with a focus on privacy, security, and transparency. This conversation benefits most from dialogue with a large number of stakeholders and is not only in the interest of societal and national security but also in our economic interest. Over the past two years of observing AI discourse, we've seen that both the most optimistic and the most concerned voices in this field have found common ground: the unprecedented potential impact of this technology on humanity. This is especially true with the advent of agentic systems that more and more remove human-in-the-loop interaction. These increasingly autonomous AI systems demonstrate advanced behaviors like emotional intelligence and manipulation, persuasion and deception. We find ourselves facing a pivotal moment—one where we must actively shape these technologies to serve humans. To shape these technologies in such a fashion requires more than just a promotion of innovation, but also the active participation of researchers and citizen stakeholders with a deep understanding of human flourishing and human values.